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Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, JULY 24, 2025 • \$4

Evidence of classified details in Signal chat

Hegseth messages were derived from ‘SECRET’ email, watchdog is told

BY DAN LAMOTHE AND JOHN HUDSON

The Pentagon’s independent watchdog has received evidence that messages from Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth’s Signal account previewing a U.S. bombing campaign in Yemen were derived from a classified email labeled “SECRET/NOFORN,” people familiar with the matter said.

The revelation appears to contradict long-standing claims by the Trump administration that no classified information was divulged in unclassified group chats that critics have called a significant security breach.

The messages about the bombing campaign, posted in at least two group chats using the unclassified messaging app Signal, are the focus of an inquiry by the Defense Department inspector general’s office requested in April by Republican and Democratic members of the Senate Armed Services Committee.

The strike plans had been shared in a classified email with more than a dozen defense officials by Gen. Michael “Erik” Kurilla, the top commander overseeing U.S. military operations in the Middle East, and then were posted in the unclassified group chats by an account affiliated with Hegseth on March 15, shortly before the United States began attacking Houthi militants, the people familiar with the matter said.

The “SECRET” classification of Kurilla’s email, which has not previously been reported, denoted that the information was

SEE HEGSETH ON A6

Microsoft hack: Breach hit U.S. nuclear and health agencies. **A15**

Ukrainians protest after Zelensky defangs anti-corruption watchdogs



ED RAM/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Demonstrators hold up signs — one reading “This will not be mini-Russia” — and sing in Kyiv on Wednesday. President Volodymyr Zelensky’s decision to strip Ukraine’s main anti-corruption bodies of their independence has sparked accusations that he is veering toward autocracy and set off protests across the country. **Story, A9**

House panel takes step to subpoena Epstein files

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR AND KADIA GOBA

President Donald Trump was struggling Wednesday to contain the fallout from his administration’s decision not to release the Epstein files, as a House subcommittee for the first time voted to subpoena the administration for the files and a Florida court declined to release grand jury testimony from the case.

Three House Republicans supported a measure introduced by Rep. Summer Lee (D-Pennsylvania) to demand the Justice De-

GOP struggles to contain furor as Democrats look to capitalize on issue

partment release the files. Under House rules, the full committee — led by Rep. James Comer (R-Kentucky), a Trump ally — must now issue the subpoenas.

“Subpoenas will be issued in the near future,” an Oversight spokesman said Wednesday evening. The Oversight panel also voted

to subpoena all communications about Epstein between then-President Joe Biden and his administration; as well as to subpoena a long list of other prominent figures from Democratic and Republican administrations including Bill and Hillary Clinton; former FBI director James B. Comey; former attorneys general Merrick Garland, William P. Barr, Jeff Sessions, Loretta E. Lynch, Eric Holder and Alberto Gonzales; as well as former special counsel Robert S. Mueller III.

It’s unclear why lawmakers felt those officials would be instru-

mental to hear from, though the federal investigation into Epstein spans two decades and several presidential administrations. Republicans believe Bill Clinton may be mentioned in the Epstein files and appear to be attempting to expose correspondence between the former president, attorneys and law enforcement officials who may have had knowledge of the case.

The cracks starting to emerge in the GOP coalition signaled the firestorm over Epstein has far from abated and may intensify as

SEE EPSTEIN ON A4

180,000 migrants could have trackers

ANKLE MONITOR USE WILL VASTLY EXPAND

ICE targets all enrolled in Alternatives to Detention

BY DOUGLAS MACMILLAN AND SILVIA FOSTER-FRAU

U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement has directed personnel to sharply increase the number of immigrants they shackle with GPS-enabled ankle monitors, as the Trump administration widens surveillance of people it is targeting for deportation, according to an internal ICE document reviewed by The Washington Post.

In a June 9 memo, ICE ordered staff to place ankle monitors on all people enrolled in the agency’s Alternatives to Detention program “whenever possible.” About 183,000 adult migrants are enrolled in ATD and had previously consented to some form of tracking or mandatory check-ins while they waited for their immigration cases to be resolved. Currently, just 24,000 of these individuals wear ankle monitors.

One exception would be pregnant women, who would be required to wear wrist-worn tracking devices, Dawnisha M. Helland, an acting assistant director in the management of non-detained immigrants, wrote in the letter. “If the alien is not being arrested at the time of reporting, escalate their supervision level to GPS ankle monitors whenever possible and increase reporting requirements,” Helland wrote.

The new ankle monitor guidance, which has not been

SEE MONITORS ON A20

Prisoner swap: Man returned by Venezuela had killed 3 people. **A20**

Abrego rulings: Judges order his release in Tenn., return to Md. **B13**

VOLKSWAGEN’S SECRET

History forgot the horrors endured by laborers on the automaker’s massive cattle ranch in the Brazilian Amazon. But a priest had recorded it all.

BY TERENCE MCCOY AND MARINA DIAS

IN SANTANA DO ARAGUAIA, BRAZIL

When Ricardo Rezende Figueira saw the headline, he felt a chill run through him. It was about Volkswagen. The company said it was finally ready to atone for its past. After admitting that its staff had cooperated with Brazil’s military dictatorship to target workers for political persecution, the automaker had begun to negotiate reparations.

Rezende read to the bottom of the article, then sat for a moment, quiet.

The story didn’t say anything about the Volkswagen cattle ranch. Nor a word about the Amazon rainforest, where the company’s leadership had once presided over a property nearly twice the size of New York City. It sometimes seemed to Rezende as if no one still remembered what had happened there — the forced labor and privation, torture and violence, deception and horror. But Rezende did. He’d recorded it all.

José Ribamar Viana Nunes, 60, said he and a group of childhood friends were lured to the Volkswagen Brazil ranch by a recruiter who promised good pay and a chance to play soccer.



RAFAEL VILELA/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Perhaps it wasn’t too late, he recalled thinking.

It was early 2019. Rezende left his small apartment and walked across the street to Rio de Janeiro’s federal university, where he taught human rights and had founded a commission to study modern slave labor. At 73, gray-haired and bespectacled, he no longer resembled the shaggy Catholic priest who had led an investigation into alleged atrocities at the Vale do Rio Cristalino Ranch, owned by an eponymous subsidiary of Volkswagen Brazil. But the documentary evidence he’d gathered during that time was still with him, inside a filing cabinet. It had sat there for years.

Rezende called Rafael Garcia, a prosecutor at Brazil’s Labor Ministry. “Did you see that Volks is recognizing what it did?” Rezende recalled asking him. Maybe, he continued, it was time to investigate the Volkswagen cattle ranch, as well.

Garcia didn’t know what he was talking about. He had no idea Volkswagen had participated in one of the world’s first grand experiments in globalization half a century ago, when multinational corporations partnered with Brazil’s authoritarian regime to develop the Amazon — pressing poor, unwitting workers

SEE BRAZIL ON A10

Columbia to pay over \$200M to settle government claims

BY SUSAN SVRLUGA AND EMILY DAVIES

Columbia University and the Trump administration have reached an agreement to resolve a months-long dispute over federal research funding that made the Ivy League university a symbol of White House efforts to force cultural changes in higher education nationally.

The deal, announced Wednesday evening, requires Columbia to pay the federal government \$200 million to settle claims relat-

ed to discriminatory practices and an additional \$21 million to settle investigations brought by the U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, and adds some external oversight to the university.

It also reinstates most of the \$400 million in research grants that were frozen by the government, restores the school’s ability to receive federal funding in the future and closes investigations into the school.

The negotiations have been closely watched as the Trump

SEE COLUMBIA ON A6

Steady deflection, then a guilty plea: Interrogating a cold-case killer

BY DAN MORSE

Eugene Gligor tried to deflect. “It’s guilty until proven innocent. I get it,” he told the detectives.

They were accusing him of killing his ex-girlfriend’s mother, a crime that went unsolved for two decades. Gligor had never been questioned in the case. And now, inside a small, gray interrogation room, he didn’t budge as the detectives bored in.

“Well, honey,” one of them said, “your DNA was in the crime scene.”

Gligor, seated on a small metal chair, waved his hands up and down, struggling to collect his words. What came next wasn’t a confession. But it wasn’t exactly a denial, either.

“I don’t remember,” he said, his voice rising. “I don’t know. I don’t know. I don’t know.”

The exchange, recorded on police video obtained Tuesday by The Washington Post, offers the clearest window yet on the day Gligor’s 23 years of getting away with murder ended. As he could tell, the detectives knew he’d

SEE GLIGOR ON A2

IN THE NEWS

University of Idaho killings Bryan Kohberger was sentenced to life in prison for the 2022 murders of four students. **A8**

D.C. chief thwarted firings The police chief granted back pay to two convicted officers after the pair were pardoned in January by President Trump, an auditor found. **B13**

THE NATION As **FEMA** raced to help Texas, other states faced delays in receiving disaster aid. **A3**
The White House can remove consumer product safety regulators, the high court ruled. **A4**

THE WORLD A **commander** in Ukraine called for longer-range missiles to use against Russia. **A13**
A U.N. court has ruled that countries have a duty to limit greenhouse gas emissions. **A14**

THE ECONOMY The **EPA** has drafted a rule that would undo a landmark 2009 climate opinion related to emissions’ health effects. **A15**
President Trump called it a U.S. win, but analysts suggest Japan might benefit more initially in a newly announced trade deal. **A16**

STYLE From heavy metal to reality TV to unending wars, Ozzy Osbourne warned us of the shape of things to come. **B1**
SPORTS **Ben Shelton**, a fan favorite at the DC Open, believes playing youth football helped shape his pro tennis career. **B7**

THE REGION **George Mason** is facing its fourth Trump administration probe in as many weeks, possibly targeting its president over DEI policies. **B13**
LOCAL LIVING A **plant known** as ghost pipe has gone from an obscure herbal remedy to a star on social media.

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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54287

